

Project 5

Course name: MSJ2231 Visual Communication

Project Name: "Unequal Grief: A Video Installation on Necropolitics and Media Framing of Death"

Project Type: Installation Art

Semester of Submission: Fall 2025

Project Description:

This project explores how society assigns different values to human deaths during political violence. Inspired by Benazir Bhutto's assassination, it examines why prominent figures receive greater media attention than ordinary victims. The installation uses one large coffin to represent the political leader and smaller coffins for civilians, soldiers, and other victims. A freely moving camera repeatedly focuses on the large coffin, symbolizing the media's selective attention.

The work highlights how countless deaths can be reduced to statistics while one influential death becomes a global event.

Project Justification:

The project questions how media, political power, and public attention determine whose deaths are considered significant. It highlights how political leaders often receive collective mourning while ordinary victims are reduced to brief reports and statistics. The large coffin and smaller coffins physically represent this unequal visibility, while the camera reinforces the media's selective focus. Ultimately, the project encourages viewers to question why some deaths remain in public memory while others are forgotten.



ULAB

UNIVERSITY OF LIBERAL ARTS
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Installation Art

Course: Visual Communication

Title: Necropolitics

Done by:

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The first modality of this project revolves around a very controversial question from necropolitics: why does the public, to such a great extent, consider, recognize, and emotionally experience the death of a political leader more than the deaths of the soldiers, non-combatants, and ordinary people who perish by thousands, if not millions, in the war zones? The discrimination in mourning that is quite vivid in political violence is what this study looks into. The world-wide assassination of Benazir Bhutto in 2007 is a very powerful example of the death of one and the living in the case of Bhutto. The very instant of her death was soon followed by the international media's unending coverage, discussions over her representation, and the dawn of the memorial saga. Within hours her picture and saga were visible on the screens of the whole world. On the other hand, the hundreds who died in earlier attacks along with her party members, policemen, security forces and observers were simply recorded as casualties with no names. They were mentioned for a split second and then abandoned by the society. This striking contrast of one politician's lifetime story being glorified on the media and the other countless deaths being totally ignored, brings us to the main question of this research: by what criteria does the media determine the lives that become memorable and the deaths that fade away in the numbers?

The Concept: Unequal Grief and Selective Value of Death

The first modality signifies the interaction of media, government power and political desires in the elaboration of the value rankings. The news industry by continuously marketing the politician's image guarantees to the public one very strong and very emotional story that fits perfectly with the political agendas, public attention cycles, and the requirement for a clear national symbol. The constant portrayal of the deaths of normal people soldiers in the "war on terror," security personnel who secured Bhutto, or civilians caught in crossfire could on the other hand disclose the government's incompetence, make the story more intricate, and generate unwanted public outcry. Hence the deaths that occur attract least attention and fade away from people's memories. The modality thus makes the viewer ready to perceive the visual art work not only as an installation but also as an acknowledgment of the systems that determine who dies and who lives during the shaping of public emotion, history, and political meaning.

A Camera That Repeats Power by Choosing What to See

The second way of expression focuses on the creation and how its visual dynamics relate to the order of sorrow. In the creation, there is no limitation to the camera's movement. It is free to go wherever it likes, to capture all the coffins, and to offer a non-selective view of all the bodies

shown. However, despite this freedom, the camera constantly chooses to focus on the large coffin only the politician in a metaphorical sense. This coffin is very prominent, and the fact that it is the loudest makes it surrounded by and therefore more pronounced and emphasized. The others are a few and small coffins representing soldiers, civilians, and others whose losses are hidden under the noise of the elite death hype.

Open to public view is the big coffin, albeit little ones hiding under it and around it. The media in the world, though, have a similar approach to the camera, which does not see them. It quickly sweeps over them or keeps them at the corner of the frame, only to then return repeatedly to the large coffin. This camera movement is intentional. It reveals that visibility per se is a power: what is frequently shown becomes significant and what is rarely seen is sidelined. So, the visual logic of the installation turns out to be a metaphor for the media's behavior. The large coffin turns into the center of national discourse drawn by the camera's constant focus on it. The numerous small coffins are left in the shadows as the camera does not give them any long attention.

Conclusively, the combination of the two modalities, the audience can perceive how the death was publicly perceived after being repeated, framed, and selectively focused on. The idea pulls apart the politics of unequal mourning, while the installation merely illustrates it, letting the observer go through the daily media-generated imbalance.



Learnings and Outcomes (Self-reflection):

- Understand necropolitics and how political power decides whose deaths are publicly mourned and whose are erased.
- Learn to translate a theoretical, academic concept into a concrete visual installation that an audience can read without a written explanation.
- Develop a critical understanding of media framing, particularly how repeated camera focus manufactures the significance of certain deaths over others.
- Use visual symbolism deliberately, letting the size and placement of the coffins carry the argument about unequal grief.
- Improve the ability to write an artist/concept statement that clearly walks a viewer through the modalities and intent behind an installation.

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